https://doi.org/10.7592/FEJF2026.99.avdikos

Lament Songs Glorifying Greek Soldiers Killed in Battle During the Balkan Wars (1912–1913)

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Abstract: The aim of the text is to study the way in which the funeral song, a mournful, interactive, narrative genre that frames the ritual process of exit from life is transformed when its content changes. In other words, interaction between the morphological expression and the content on the one hand and social function on the other hand is a basic issue in the text. The tradition of lament in Greek history is not a modern phenomenon. It became a significant poetic art in the *Iliad* by Homer, who, however, used the existing poetic tradition. Taking into consideration this historical tradition, an attempt is made to understand the way in which the funeral song is used as a genre of oral literature, in order to honor and glorify those who were killed while fighting for the liberation of the homeland.

Keywords: lament, ritual process, history, narrative genre, oral literature, Homer

I dealt with the subject of death and how it is represented in discourse several years ago, when I was asked to take part in a two-day colloquium on the Greek poet Georgios Zalokostas, in whose poetry death is diffuse. He focuses on death in two ways: in the first he concentrates on those sacrificed on the battlefields

to safeguard the value system of the group, in which case he uses the "rhetoric of public lamentation", while in the second, which laments the death of several of his offspring, "he resorts to the rich tradition of the lament song" (Avdikos 2001: 411–412). Things are clear for the poet Zalokostas; he uses a different poetic form for the "honourable death" of those killed in battle than for the untimely death of his sons.

What happens, however, in the case where the lament song is used to praise the dead in battle? It is generally agreed that the lament is the poetry of the final parting, of the exodus from life (Honko 1974: 9). Fedakâr points out that the poetry of the lament is diffused in ancient Turkish literature and notes as its principal trait its identification with death, and specifically with the procedure of the departure of the deceased from the world of the living (2010: 122; Šunde 2006: 682). In this sense, laments exist the world over and their beginnings are to be traced back to the remote past, as all men must face the exit from life and the unease, as well as the angst, about what awaits them after death.

The Greek word for lament, *μοιρολόγι* (pl. *μοιρολόγια*), is a compound formed from the noun *μοίρα* (fate) and the verb *λέγω* (to say, to speak about). The lament is therefore the dialogical narrative discourse framing the ceremonial procedure not only of the departure from life, but also of the transition and repositioning of the relations between the living (Bourke 1993). One other basic issue raised by the investigation of laments is the interaction between the formal expression and the content on the one hand, and the social function on the other. Specifically, laments, as the dictional part of a ritual process, can contribute to the decipherment of its basic character. The close interaction between stylistic and thematic units on the one hand, and social function on the other has far-reaching implications, behind the use of poetic conventions, as they serve to affect rather than merely to describe behaviour (Caraveli-Chaves 1980: 156).

The tradition of the lament in Greek history is not a recent phenomenon. The lament was enhanced as a potent poetic art in Homer's *Iliad*, which utilized the existing poetic tradition. In many cultures, including that of ancient Greece, women were the composers and singers of powerful, sophisticated oral lament poetry (Kurtz & Boardman 1971: 30). At the end of the *Iliad*, the Trojans gather at the palace of Priam for Hector's funeral. The lamentation begins with the *threnos* (24.720-21), performed by professional singers, followed by the *gooi*, the dirges of Hector's kinswomen[1] – Andromache, Hecabe, and Helen –, individual laments mourning Hector's death and the devastating consequences of his loss for the city and its people. Their songs are answered antiphonally by a refrain of wails and cries from a chorus of Trojan women (Pantelia 2002: 21).

Researchers agree that the incorporation of this lament in the epic is due to the mourning tradition cultivated for centuries by women in their daily life, when they bid farewell to their loved ones. Indeed, they go one step further, arguing that: "the forms of Homeric epics are cognate or derive from a common

source - women's prayer uttered in group lament" (Weinbaum 2001: 21; Nagy 1974). However, in the transition from the private to the public space, with the creation of epic poetry, the mourning tradition becomes valuable material in the hands of the bards, who create the new narrative forms by utilizing the formal as well as the thematic components of the dirge. Thus, I contend that the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey* may actually be examples of original female creation and secondary male transmission, a pattern that obscures women's participation in the creation of myth and culture. That is, the men who record and transmit the epics become the cultural historians and later leave the original women who might have created the project out of their official discourse (Weinbaum 2001: 21). Death and mourning in Homer are unavoidably connected to the concept of heroic *kleos*, that is, the glory that epic poetry grants to its greatest heroes. In the context of the *Iliad*, where premature death is viewed as an inevitable reality, *kleos* functions as compensation for early death and as the means of attaining a different kind of immortality (Pantelia 2002: 23; Meltzer 1994: 235).

Taking this historical tradition into account, an attempt is made here to understand the way in which the lament, as an oral literary genre, was employed to honour and glorify those killed while fighting for the liberation of their fatherland. This endeavour was stimulated by the lament songs created by women, mainly, in the region of Mani, which were published by Politis in the fourth volume of the periodical *Laographia*, which circulated after the end of the Balkan Wars. These laments paid homage to soldiers who lost their lives in the battles of 1912–1913, for the liberation of Greek lands still subject to the Ottoman Empire. The lamentation took place in Mani, in the homes of the dead, except in the cases of the two laments referring to King George, who was assassinated in Thessaloniki (1913) after the city's liberation (October 1912), which were chanted in churches in Mani in commemoration of the loss.

MANI, THE GEOGRAPHICAL REGION

Mani (Maina, Magne) is the name given to the middle of the three southern headlands of the Peloponnese. Its seaward end is Cape Matapan. On the landward side its boundaries are less clearly defined, but the line joining the northern coasts of the Gulf of Messenia and the Gulf of Laconia is a rough approximation.

The great ridge of the Taygetos runs like a spine down the thirty-five miles or so of the peninsula, dividing it into two parts – "Sunny" Mani (*Prosiliaki*) to the east, and "Shady" Mani (*Aposkiaderi*) to the west. But this division is not as important as the distinction between Outer Mani (to the north) and Inner Mani (to the south). The dividing line crosses the principal saddle of Taygetos, from Itylo and Areopolis to Gythion. Inner Mani is felt by its inhabitants to be the part of Greece which has best maintained its independence from foreign domination and therefore has the most direct connection with antiquity.

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There is a degree of truth in this, as far as freedom from Ottoman rule is concerned, but Byzantine records and modern place-names suggest considerable Slavic settlement in the Middle Ages. There has also been immigration from other parts of Greece. The Nykliani, a prominent population group in Maniot studies, preserve the memory of a movement from Nykli in the Central Peloponnese in the early thirteenth century. Even so, the southerners see themselves as the purer repository of tradition and there is a clear division of folk-song style between Inner and Outer Mani. However, the internal distinction pales in comparison to the sense of solidarity that unites all Maniots against outsiders. Mani is "an island entirely unto itself". If a Maniot goes even to neighbouring Messenia, as a hired workman for the harvest or the vintage, it is said that he is going "to the Morii" (the Peloponnesians) (Morgan 1973: 265–266; Seremetakis 1990: 485; Alexakis 1980).

THE INTRODUCTORY MOTIFS

In the fourth volume of *Laographia*, Politis publishes a total of thirteen laments, all composed by women, except for one which was created by a man. He writes: "In this first fascicle of the fourth volume of *Laographia*, the publication of which has been delayed for a long time by national events, we have decided to give precedence to two extempore folk poems, in which are expressed without affectation the feelings captivating the soul of the Greek people in the critical hour of its life. And this expression of feelings is true and unfeigned, because it was made at that moment when the overflowing of the heart summons the mouth, when there is no room for pretence, by naïve and unschooled peasant women, who through improvised laments mourn the beloved deceased" (Politis 1912–1913: 3).

Politis understands the importance of this poetic creation, which he attributes to "naïve and unschooled peasant women". There is a problem regarding this point, even though the poetic material that reaches Politis's hands has the stamp of the poetic creation of an illiterate woman or a village woman.

The lamenters use the formal and thematic characteristics of the lament song, which is shifted to another ideological field. A case in point is "the lament for Livanas's son", which has attracted the interest of several researchers (Morgan 1972: 265–298). The first scholar after Politis who was involved with this lament was Rhomaios, in an article entitled "Venizelos in a lament from Mani" (1980: 218–225). Obviously, the aim of this text is not Venizelos but the change of epicentre in an oral literary genre. "The lament dramatizes death, and the heartbreak itself, precisely because it is an extreme and condensed – truly unbearable – form of mourning, allows and facilitates the subsequent relief and the appeasing of pain" (Saunier 1999: 23).

The lament begins with a typical introduction, in which the woman who wants to sing the lament asks the permission of the deceased's loved ones

to do so. This is a necessary structural element, which the woman preparing to continue the lament bears in mind. In this particular case, Dimosthenaina Kouvarina, who lost her own son in the battle of Sarantaporos in Western Macedonia, addresses the dead youth's mother (Stavrianni), as well as the other women, to left and right.

Dear Stavrianni,	*Χαιράμενή μου Σταυριανού,*
your every wish is mine.	*που να χαρής ό τι αγαπάς,*
Women, to left and right,	*κι' από δεξιά κι' από ζερβιά,*
allow me to begin	*μόνε και μένα άφες μου.*

From the opening lines the world of the lament is composed, a cosmos that is the privileged space of the womenfolk. This space is reconstituted in the singing of the lament, and through its specific ceremonial the womenfolk reinforce their ties (Caraveli-Chaves 1980: 130), project their power and are enhanced as visible structural elements of the strictly structured patriarchal society of Mani. The same introductory motif is encountered in several of the laments cited in this article.

FROM THE INDIVIDUAL PAIN FOR DEATH TO THE SACRIFICE FOR THE FATHERLAND

The Individual Pain

Included in this category are three laments in which there is a gradation of individual pain. These laments belong to the cycle of traditional folk (demotic) songs in which the lamenter focuses on classical motifs of the folk culture as well as of the laments.

1. In one of these laments, the sister of the deceased, after referring to the historical circumstances that led to the mobilization and death of her brother, Giannis Michaleas, as well as levelling accusation against the Prime Minister Venizelos and the "King's son who became also a general and who too was glorified" (Manolakos 1912–1913: 276), infuses her personal pain, that of the sister who feels she is orphaned because her brothers were recruited to the army[1].

I thought that I the wretched one,	*Ενόμισα η δύστυχη*
that I would not fall low,	*ότι δεν έχω ξεπεσμούς,*
because I had five brothers,	*γιατ' είχα πέντε αδερφούς,*
and all five in the fire,	*κ' οι πέντε απάνου'ς τη φωτιά,*
in the front line of battle.	*'ς την πρώτη ζώνη της γραμμής.*
But I was left the orphan	*Αλλ' έμεινα η ορφανή*
like the crow upon the branch.	*σαν την κουρούνα 'ς το κλαρί.*
O my Giannos Michaleas	*Άι Γιάννο Μιχαλέα μου*
you took the wind from my sails.	*μ' έκοψες τον αγέρα μου.*

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This is the pain at being orphaned herself (But I was left the orphan / like the crow upon the branch) but also for the danger of the fall in social status of the family, and consequently of herself, who would be bereft of male support. This worry about personal and family degradation leads her to exploit someone else, in the person of her brother, the parliamentary deputy, who has a different view about the war. For him, sacrifice in war is the legitimization of political authority. This view is not, of course, expressed by the lamenter, nonetheless, it is incorporated in the antiphonic structure of the lament (Briggs 1993)[2].

And you said to me: "My Coronet,	*Και μου είπες: "Κορωνίτσα μου,*
I want to be an MP	*εγώ θενά είμαι βουλευτής*
and Giannos with the long sword,	*κι' ο Γιάννος με μακρύ σπαθί,*
shall bring glory to our house."	*το σπίτι μας να δοξαστή."*

2. The second lament which is limited to the traditional motifs is "the lament for a man [from Argos] slain in the battle of Tzoumagia" (Simitzopoulos 1912–13: 680).

Cease, O brother Mitsos, and my cousin Giannis.	*Παύσε, βρε Μήτσο αδερφέ, και ξάδερφέ μου Γιάννη.*
Come and do battle for me for I am slain.	*Ελάτε να με μάσετε που είμαι σκοτωμένος.*
Those curs the Bulgarians slayed me.	*Εμένα με σκοτώσανε, κείν' τα σκυλιά οι Βουλγάροι.*
Do battle for my blood, lest they pollute it.	*Το αίμα μου να μάσετε μήπως και το μολύνουν,*

The lament (lines 3–11) uses expressive means and imagery which are common in laments in order to state the most important issue, which is declared by the deceased himself. His wish that the war will end has as its starting point a concept inherent in laments and in folk culture in general – the good death, which is the prerequisite for completion of the deceased's journey with his final incorporation into the world of the dead. In other words, the precondition for a good death, which reflects primarily upon the deceased but also his family, is the ceremonial burial of the deceased (Bourke 1993: 388). What the deceased undergoes is extreme humiliation; he experiences a "bad" death.

3. In the third lament (of Kastri, Kynouria) there is concern again about the good death, in which the same anxiety is expressed by the deceased's wife, after she first expresses her intense desolation at her husband's death. In the conclusion of the lament, the wife returns to the motif of the good death, about which she worries.

I weep not for the killing,	*Εγώ δεν κλαίω το σκοτωμό,*
I weep that they buried you	*μό*[ον] *κλαίω που σε θάψαν*
[without coffin]	[με χωρίς κάσσα]
without incense and candle,	*χωρίς λιβάνι και κερί,*
without priest and cantor	*χωρίς παπά και ψάλτη.*

However, despite the quantitative superiority of the individual and family death, what is formulated is the shift of the epicentre of the lament to another level – the national – which reflects the prevailing of national consciousness over the local and familial tie.

O Stelios you did not do good,	*Στέλιο δεν το έπραξες καλά,*
leaving behind a widow with orphans.	*ν' αφήσης χήρα μ' ορφανά.*
"What can I do for you, my dear Despo,	*– Τι να σου κάμω, Δέσπω μου,*
do you think I wanted it so?	*μήπως κ' εγώ το θέλω;*
it was the King wanted us to part,	*"για να χωρίσουμε ο Βασιλιάς ηθέλησε,*
for him for the fatherland,	*όπου για την πατρίδα, όπου*
for him was I slain"	*φονεύτηκα.*

THE GOOD DEATH FOR THE FATHERLAND

Most of the laments exploit the formal elements of the *moirologi* in order to reorient its social function by giving death a different content. "Death on the field of military operations goes beyond its biological dimension. It is not simply the end of existence. It is the beginning for the reproduction of the cultural system" (Avdikos 2001: 406).

We should remember that the laments were created for those who fell on the battlefields for the liberation of territories under Ottoman rule (Epirus, part of Thessaly and Macedonia 1912–1913) and their incorporation into the hitherto small Greek State. War, particularly war of liberation, needs ceremonies that will make time stand still, so that the national group can be remustered with the redrawing of the borders (Marvin & Ingle 1999: 248).

Laments of this category try to transform the ceremonial procedure of the traditional *threnos* into a field of national ratification and of repositioning the relationship between the local and the national (Adebanwi 2008: 420).

Specifically, the "lament for Livanas's son" is turned, on the pretext of mourning the dead soldier, into a doxology of the national struggle. The structure imprints the reassessment of the ideological discourse of the lament, which loses its philosophical/cosmological character concerning life and death, and is historicized through its inclusion in the effort to constitute collective memory. Paraphrasing the views of Morinis (1985), we could say that the individual pain and the consequent ceremonial are used as a means for the

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transition of the deceased, and his family, from the individual and collective daily round, as well as the introverted localist viewpoint, to the field of national consciousness and recognition of another, macro-level field of acknowledgement and identification[3].

This is crystal clear in the lament for Livanas. Familiar formal traits of the specific poetic genre are used to transform it, at least from the standpoint of content, into epic poetry, if we bear in mind that epic poetry functions as an agent of living testimonies (Konate Deme 2009: 404). The lament does indeed intersect the generic boundaries and can be perceived as having nuclei of historical and epic poetry. It draws on the known function of the lament, **commemorative rhetoric**, according to which "the past makes the present. Commemoration is a way of claiming that the past has something to offer the present" (Olick 1999: 381), in other words, that memories, memorial services and stories are semeiological means for negotiating the past (Konate Deme 2009: 404).

So, in the lament for Livanas the "weeping" over the deceased is used as a means for changing the content of the procedure. A traditional practice (social control) is utilized in order to constitute the *kleos* (glory) of the dead, in accordance with ancient Greek habit. The specific lament is organized around five axes: the introductory motif, the historical framework – Balkan alliance, the good death, the local, the national and diplomacy. In the historical framework it describes briefly the Balkan environment and introduces the leadership figure of Venizelos, who dominates these laments to a greater or lesser extent. In the social control, the lament criticizes the deceased's father, who went to Ioannina in order to see the place of his son's martyrdom

> *Come close by me, O Livanas,* *Έλα κοντά μου, Λιβανά,*
> *who went up to the fighting.* *που διάηκες εκεί κοντά.*
> *Tell me, what did you get from it?* *Για πες μου τι καζάντησες;*

In other words, it considers that the projection of paternal interest is fruitless. What comes first and foremost in this war is the response to the national duty and not the life of sons. This view is absolute and brings to mind the bidding of Spartan mothers to their sons when they left for battle: *ή ταν ή επί τας* (Either with this [= the shield] or upon it), in other words, Come back victorious or dead.

> *for they were bound for Yannina,* *τι κείνα παν 'ς τα Γιάνναινα*
> *to conquer the Turk* *τον Τούρκο να νικήσουσι,*
> *and if they did not conquer him,* *κι α δεν τόνε νικήσουσι,*
> *they would not come back.* *πίσου να μη γυρίσουσι*

Next comes the reference to the good death, in other words, to the historical events that give a different meaning to the slain soldier's departure from life. After mentioning Mavromichalaina's answer to Venizelos's telegram that her officer son had been killed on the battlefield (he did his duty), it ends in the frame that adds a different dimension to the death[4].

> *I do not begrudge his death,* *Χαλάλι του ο θάνατος,*
> *for he has freed a people!* *γιατί λευτέρωσε λαό!*

Death, now, is not dealt with as a biological loss but as sacrifice for national integration. Mavromichalaina's son Livanas and all the others become martyrs for Greece's territorial expansion. According to Marvin and Ingle, "sacrifice to the totem god, the nation, implies the existence of a religious community of devotees who carry out the religious mission. This community is the military one" (1999: 99). This was precisely the role and the contribution of the Maniots who fell on the battlefields of the Balkan Wars. Their sacrifice links both them and their families to a wider community, the national one. This is a differentiation from what was considered a good death in the traditional laments and what the bloodshed of the menfolk of Mani served. It is imprinted in the lament for Livanas.

> *But have we become cowards* *Μα μήπως εβλαχέψαμε*
> *without our knowing it?* *και δεν το καταλάβαμε;*

What develops in this lament is a peculiar antiphonic dialogue between Demosthenaina and what is heard in Mani, or the way in which the death of loved ones in war is faced (Seremetakis 1990: 493–496). This is also the focal point of the lament of eighty-year-old Panagou Frangakou, who participates in the lamenting of Petros I. Michalakakos, killed in the battle of Tzoumagia. The lamenter reminds us of the resistance spirit of Maniot culture. She berates mercilessly the other women who preceded in the lamenting and who used the typical mode of the lament for loss and pain.

> *Don't get me wrong,* *Μη με παραξηγήσετε,*
> *You've fouled our land,* *τον τόπο μας βρωμίσατε,*
> *You've insulted your menfolk,* *τους άντρες σας προσβάλλετε,*
> *You've shamed our land* *τον τόπο μας ντροπιάζετε*

This dimension is pointed out also by the dead man's brother in the "Lament for Mitsos Demestichas", from the village of Alepou in Mani, who was killed at Ano Tzoumagia. It is addressed to his mother, whose lament preceded and probably focused on pain and bereavement.

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> *Listen, mother, let me tell you,* *Άκουε, μάννα, να σου πω,*
> *be patient if you can* *α θέλης κάμ' υπομονή,*
> *as we too will be patient,* *όπως θα κάμωμε και μεις,*
> *because it was not only* *γιατί δεν ήταν μοναχός*
> *our own brother there,* *ο δικός μας αδερφός,*
> *it was everybody there* *εκεί τα κόσμος και ντουνιάς*
> (Manolakos 1912–1913: 679)

He reminds her of the qualitative difference in relation to what was happening in Maniot society as a whole. The deceased is now included in a collectivity. And this is argued too by the daughter-in-law of Petros Michalkos's paternal aunt.

> *Say never mind, what will be* *Πέστε χαλάλι να γενή*
> *that the body of Petros* *κείνο του Πέτρου το κορμί,*
> *was lost for Greece* *τι εχάθηκε για την Ελλάς*
> *and for other brothers in bondage.* *και γι' άλλ' αδέρφια της σκλαβιάς.*
> (Manolakos 1912–1913: 673)

The lamenter, who represents her mother-in-law, empathizes with her weakness (*what are they wanting to say to you, even though they've little brain*), possibly because this is a different way of thinking and of articulating the traditional lament. The deceased "was lost for Greece". This is another target, which did not belong in the experiences of the Maniots' introverted bellicose society for many years.

Consequently, in the period of the Balkan Wars the laments function as a space of creation and community dialogue, in which issues of cultural values and identities of Maniot society are broached. Mani has entered a critical period for its social organization. With the creation of the Greek State, an introverted society organized around the clans and the vendetta as the means of restructuring social relations and resolving differences was incorporated into the basically military[5] mechanism, and through this the Maniots acquired access to power. As a result, they look to the manipulation of the State in order to achieve pecuniary, individual and family goals. Characteristic is the petition of the sister of the dead soldier Giannis Michaleas, and of her father, to her brother the parliamentary deputy, to intervene to prevent the recruitment of Giannis, in which case he would not have been killed.

> *What of it if you are a deputy,* *Τι όντες που γίνης βουλευτής,*
> *and you've entered Parliament,* *και μπήκες μέσ'ς τη Βουλή,*
> *I told you and I spoke to you of it,* *σου το είπα και σ' το μίλησα,*
> *both I and father:* *κ'εγώ και ο πατέρας:*

> *"Our Giannos should be exempted* *"Ο Γιάννος μας να ξαιρεθή*
> *and not enlisted in the Army."* *και 'ς το στρατό να μη γραφτή."*
> (Politis 1912–1913: 277)

In other words, she considers the parliamentary deputy Vasilis responsible for the fact that their brother Giannis was killed at Giannitsa[6], and for this reason she curses him.

> *Put on mourning black,* *Να βάλης μαύρα να φορής,*
> *the Long Sword has been lost.* *τι χάθη το Μακρύ σπαθί.*
> (Politis 1912–1913: 277)

Obviously, the Maniots have a special relationship with the central bureaucracy, and the dialogue in the laments concerning the allegation of cowardice, an allegation that could have caused a vendetta in the past, is possibly due to this relationship. Indicative is the way in which the dead man's grandmother answers Demosthenaina in the "lament for Livanas", through her lament.

> *But listen, Dimosthinen.* *Αλλ' άκου, Δημοστέναινα.*
> *These things are all lies.* *Ετούτα είναι ψέματα.*
> *Our men are being slandered* *Τους άντρες μας κακίζουσι,*
> *and insulted slyly.* *τουςε συκοφαντίζουσι.*
> *They're making them seem cowards* *Τους παρασταίνουσι δειλούς.*
> *– it was written in the newspapers!* *– Το γράψασι και'ς το χαρτί.*
> (Politis 1912–1913: 10)

The subject of the dialogue is a product of the transition of Maniot society. In the past, the dialogue in the lament songs concerned issues of control of the council of elders for its acts, as well as issues of reinstating social equilibrium by using the vendetta. In the laments of the Balkan Wars, the doubting of the central axis of the value system of Maniot society, valour, is put on the table. This is expressed in the phrase "*But have we become cowards*", which is voiced in Demosthenaina's lament. In other words, have we become wimps? Have we perhaps lost the cultural soul of our martial and introverted society? The dead man's grandmother reacts vehemently to this insinuation which casts shadows.

> *You made me sad, my daughter,* *Με πίκρανες, παιδάκι μου,*
> *and I shall call you foolish.* *και θα σε που ανόητη.*
> *What is it that you said?* *Το τι ναι τούτο που είπεκες;*
> *That it's shameful and wrong* *ότι είναι ντρέπος και κακό*
> *to mourn for our children?* *να κλαίμε τα παιδία μας.*

No, people mourn their children	*Τα κλαίσι τα παιδία τους,*
Spartan mothers mourn them	*τα κλαίσι κ' οι Σπαρτιάτισσαις*
and the Mavromichilenes.	*κ' οι Μαυρομιχαλιάνισσαις*

She dismisses all the rumors as lies and slanders, and invokes the Prime Minister's declaration which denies the allegation. In addition, what is interesting is the women's public dialogue on the symptoms of the differentiation of the local ethos[7]. Having as a starting point a common practice – social control – the women widen their boundaries and discuss a matter of decisive importance for the Maniots, undoubtedly transmitting, too, the unofficial dialogue being conducted in Mani. "In the early years of Greek independence (1830s), the Maniote chiefs, who felt that they had contributed so much to the struggle for liberation, were out-manoeuvred in the political turmoil of the new state. In particular, they had attached themselves closely to Otho, the new king imported from Bavaria and had suffered severely in his disgrace and expulsion. From then on, Maniote influence in politics was very small, and economic aid to the area was slight" (Morgan 1973: 292).

The dead man's grandmother expresses the new extrovert policy that the Maniots must follow, through claiming high offices in the new source of power, the State. This is predicated on adopting education as the basic orientation of the Maniot family. Through the lamenting woman's words, a new policy is proposed, abandoning introversion.

Send your children	*Στέλνετε τα παιδία σας*
to school [we've got one here]	*'ς το σχολαρχεί*[είναι πα]
to learn to read and write.	*να μάθουσι τα γράμματα*
Some day the time will come	*και θα ρθη κι' άλλη εποχή,*
for a Maniot to be senator,	*να πάη Μανιάτης'ς τη Βουλή,*
a Maniot to be minister,	*να είναι Μανιάτης υπουργός,*
to stand up for our rights.	*ναν το μιλά το δίκιο τους.*

The prosperity of Mani will come through Maniots assuming ministerial positions. This is the acceptance of the clientage policy, around which the Greek State was organized.

It is obvious that the shifting of the frame of the laments to the historical domain and the sacrifice for the fatherland gives new meaning to their content. Death is not a family event: it is an act that reinforces national self-determination and the formation of national identity. This is a change which also influences customary behaviours in the mourning process. Such is the case of the lament for Giannis Arvanitis, who was killed at Bizani. The dead soldier's mother exhorts his widow, her daughter-in-law, not to follow the customs observed in such circumstances.

> *I'll give you advice* *Εγώ θα δώσου συμβουλή*
> *and I'll give you my blessing* *και θα σου δώσου την ευκή*
> *Wear your red ribbon* *το μπογασί ναν το φορής*
> *no matter that for me it's bad* *τι γω το έχου για κακό*
> *and a great insult* *και για μεγάλη προσβολή*
> (Politis 1912–1913: 676)

The mourning mother of the deceased opposes the cultural habit of taking off the red ribbon, a discreet symbol for expressing happiness[8]. Death on the battlefield and bloodshed function as the foundation stone for expanding the borders of the Nation State. The blood of the son and husband is not wasted. It soaks the root of the national constitution and brings renewal of the national team, through warfare for territorial expansion. For this reason, the social status of the widow does not change. What happened does not make her a weak widow who has lost her husband, her protector. To the contrary, the sacrifice of the slain husband places her, too, among the choir of heroic kinsmen who laid down their lives for the fatherland. Thus, the loss of her husband does not cancel the status of the married woman. It gives her the possibility of being rewarded by keeping her social status, because she has not lost her husband by the usual biological death.

> *"He lived with glory, with honour.* *Διάη με δόξα , με τιμή.*
> *The King called him."* *Τον κάλεσε ο Βασιλιά*
> (Politis 1912–1913: 676)

VENIZELOS IN THE LAMENTS

These last two lines give the death another meaning. The dead "lives" in glory; he is included in the portrait gallery of heroes who with their sacrifice founded and expanded the Nation State, which is represented in this particular case by its supreme head, the king, as well as by the then prime minister, Eleftherios Venizelos.

> *Good too is the Cretan,* *Καλός είναι κι' ο Κρητικός,*
> *a great man is he.* *είναι μεγάλος άνθρωπος.*
> *A thousand good deeds may he do* *Χίλια καλά να κάμουσι*
> *for all those who voted for him* *όσοι τόνε ψηφίσασι*
> *and brought him here,* *και τόνε φέρασι επά,*
> *to enlarge Greece.* *να μεγαλώση την Ελλάς.*
> (Politis 1912–1913: 9)

The lamenting women's relation to the current political history is exceptionally interesting, to the point that Morgan's ascertainment that the content of these laments can be characterized as constituting a political and international diplomatic history of the Balkan Wars is remarkably apt – as this is understood by the illiterate women in Mani[9].

This is clear in the next excerpt, which focuses on the decision of the revolutionary committee of the Goudi *coup d'état* (1909) to entrust the governance of the country to Eleftherios Venizelos, in order to "enlarge Greece". This is achieved also by Venizelos's participation in international summits

Our Venizelos	*το Βενιζέλο μας*
has been invited to go	*τόνε καλέσασι να πα,*
and join the gerontiki[10]	*να κάμη την γεροντική*
in the capital of England).	*'ς την αγγλική πρωτεύουσα.*

So, the lament is transformed into epic poetry, with its hero being the premier Venizelos and, secondarily, the king. Characteristic is the way in which the lament for Petros I. Michalakakos, killed at Tzoumagia[11], is structured. The lamenter dedicates some twenty of the one hundred and twenty-six lines in the dirge to the introduction and to the control of the women who had mourned, before this, the men and their sons but who also considered Venizelos responsible for their pain. The rest of the lines are a lesson in political, military and diplomatic history, from an illiterate and almost blind woman.

and he came to the Parliament	*και ήρθε απάνου στη Βουλή*
they made him Prime Minister	*τον έκαμαν Πρωθυπουργό*
to direct the Parliament	*να διευτύνη τη Βουλή,*
to bring all good things,	*να φέρη όλα τα καλά,*
to stop the bad.	*να σταματήση τα κακά.*

Indicative are the thematic axes of the lament (1. Ignorance of history – control of women. 2. The Goudi *coup* and Venizelos. 3. The Balkan Alliance and the defeat of the Turks. 4. The Second Balkan War).

Truly remarkable is the illiterate lamenter's navigation through the sea of national and international politics. It could be argued that the information included in the lament seems like a journalist's summary report. In this sense, it corroborates the views of Bauman and Briggs that "a central device for connecting narrated and narrating events is reported speech; a growing body of research has built upon the insights of Volosinov. Reported speech enables performers to increase stylistic and ideological heterogeneity by drawing on multiple speech events, voices, and points of view. As we show below, this decentering of the narrating event and of the narrator's voice opens up possibilities

for renegotiating meanings and social relations beyond the parameters of the performance itself" (1990: 70).

The lamenter has her ear turned to many sources. First of all, she seems to be interested in narrating the historical and political events, which are given new meaning in the lament, the relations of the dead man's family with the community, as well as the position of Mani itself in the new space that is taking shape. The lament sketches Venizelos's difficult struggle to reform the State, both on the domestic front

(He imprisoned brigands,	*Τους κλέφτες εφυλάκισε,*
he threw out the incapable,	*ανίκανους επέταξε,*
he trained the army,	*και το στρατό εγύμνασε,*
so that it was ready for action	*για να τον έχη έτοιμο.)*

and in its relations with other states, particularly with the territories to which Greece laid claim, in order to liberate them, which provoked the aggressive policy of the Turkish authorities towards the natives:

He did not want the war.	*Τον πόλεμο δεν ήθελε.*
Those Paliagarenes,	*Εκείνοι οι Παλιαγαρηνοί,*
Turks and unchristened ones,	*οι Τούρκοι και οι αβάφτιστοι,*
women tortured,	*γυναίκες προεβάνασι,*
priests jailed,	*παπάδες φυλακίζασι,*
bishops mocked	*δεσπότες κοροϊδεύασι.*

The lamenter tells of Venizelos's efforts to forge an alliance of Balkan forces in order to confront the Turks, while she also refers to how he was forced to declare war on Bulgaria, which laid claim to Greek territories in northern Greece. This is, without a doubt, an impressive knowledge of the diplomatic and political history of the Balkan Wars, which is presented with brevity and narrative force.

THE LAMENT FOR THE KING

Particularly interesting are the laments for King George I, who was assassinated in Thessaloniki (18 March 1913), where he had settled after its liberation (26 October 1912), in order to be closer to political developments following the Bulgarians' entry into the city. The people of Mani mourn the killing of the king, but they do so in church. The structure of the following lament (Politis 1912–1913: 272), which was sung by an illiterate peasant-woman in the Maniot village of Oitylos on the day of the king's funeral, is indicative of how the sentiments generated affect the mourning of the monarch.

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The laments mourning the loss of the king focus essentially on that process by which the death of a ruling figure and his memorial service contribute to the constitution of national memory and history (Adebanwi 2008: 420). The lamenters of the king express a collective pain (*the* papa *and the king of the Greeks has been killed, our father has been slain*), which indicates the change of the political model in Maniot society. Although the local council of elders continues to have authority in the local community, the institution of the Nation State has created another authoritative superstructure which is represented by the king. With the patriarchal structure of the family as tool, it now widens the boundaries of this structure by putting as head of the national patriarchy the figure of the king, whose death evokes feelings corresponding to those evoked by the death of the *pater familias*.

Consequently, the memorial service becomes the occasion for expressing the anxieties caused by the death of the king, as well as the determination to secure the survival and the expansion of the Nation State. Thus, the Maniots now project their localism into a wider collectivity, which links them to the traditions relating to the recapture of Constantinople, which fell to the Ottomans in 1453.

> *Our Crown Prince our King* *Ο Διαδοχός μας βασιλιάς*
> *Constantine the mighty,* *ο Κωνσταντίνος ο τρανός,*
> *the twelfth he is too.* *δωδέκατος ήρθε κι' αυτός.*
> *O God, bring it to pass,* *Θε μου και κάμε μια δουλειά,*
> *to go to Constantinople as king.* *να πάη'ς τη Πόλη βασιλιάς.*
> (Politis 1912–1913: 272)

This motif is encountered in several historical folk (demotic) songs of Greece. Therefore, the change of content, namely the confrontation of death as sacrifice for the collective weal, transforms the function and the aim of the mourning process, which becomes a field for praising the dead, by manipulating to advantage the formal traits of the genre.

In this way, the memorial and the laments "turned the action of a single man into the representation of a collective (ethnic) disposition, and a representation of the positive qualities of his people" (Adebanwi 2008: 440). So, the women lamenting the king do not forget their interest in their homeland and their compatriots. The image of Hades, with the king arriving in the Underworld and encountering the dead Maniots, certainly alludes to motifs of both epic poetry and lament songs.

> *Now that the king is weeping* *Τώρα που κλαίει ο βασιλιάς και*
> *and everyone is weeping* *κλαίει ο κόσμος όλος*
> *he will also issue a decree* *θα βγάλη μια μία διαταγή*

> *within Hades and within the black earth,* *'στον Άδη και 'στη μαύρη γη,*
> *for those brave lads to meet,* *να συναχτούνε τα παιδιά,*
> *those who were killed* *κείνα που σκοτωθήκανε*
> *in the mountains of Epirus,* *μέσ' 'της Ηπείρου τα βουνά,*
> *at sea and on land,* *'στη θάλασσα και 'στη στεριά,*
> *for the sweet fatherland.* *για την πατρίδα τη γλυκειά.*
> (Dimopoulos 1912–1913: 275)

Noteworthy is the transfer of the organization of the secular world to the Underworld. The king will be placed at the head of all those who were killed for the fatherland. In the lament of Marigo Leontakianakou, which "was sung in the church of the Taxiarchs of Areopolis", the lamenter takes the opportunity to upgrade the position of the slain soldiers from Mani to the bodyguard of the dead king.

> *Take those ones, O king,* *κείνα να πάρης, βασιλιά,*
> *for protection and for bodyguard.* *για φύλαξη και για φρουρά.*
> (Dimopoulos 1912–1913: 275)

In another lament (Politis 1912–1913: 693), sung in the church of St George at Areopolis, the dead George I is represented as a title-bearer who appears as head of his dead subjects:

> *The Virgin too will descend* *Θα κατεβή κ' η Παναγιά*
> *and will place him on the right,* *και θα τον βάλη στα δεξιά,*
> *because he worked well* *γιατί εργάσθηκε καλά*
> *here in the false world* *εδώ στον ψεύτικο ντουνιά)*

and who due to his position can intercede for the dead soldiers' admittance to the Underworld, which is also the final goal of the rite of passage of death.

> *Do you want me to speak to God,* *Θε να μιλήσω στο Θεό*
> *for him to find your little soul good,* *να βρη η ψυχούλα σας καλό,*
> *why you shed your blood,* *τι χύσατε το αίμα σας,*
> *as I shed it too.* *όπως το έχυσα και εγώ.*

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IN CONCLUSION: EXTEMPORE CREATION IN MANI IN 1912–1913; A CRITICAL LOOK

Those scholars who deal with the lament treat it as a basically improvised oral creation of women (Danforth 1982: 73; Seremetakis 1990: 481; Håland 2011: 191). However, the issue of the spontaneous, improvised creation is a moot one. Politis (1912–1913: 271), a leading figure in recording the folk songs, historical songs and laments with the subject of the Balkan Wars, writes:

> *The war and the events associated with it provide an opportunity for the plenteous flowering of demotic Greek poetry. Numerous are the songs which soldiers and men and women of the people sing today on various occasions, some of them improvised, others cobbled together in makeshift fashion from elements of earlier songs, adapted more or less pertinently to the prevailing circumstances. All of these indeed do not purely have the character of the folk song. Nonetheless, obvious in them is the influence of the technique of poetry but born of the moment and created to meet a temporary need ; it is not an offering to be kept for long, and several songs in this category have faults of many kinds or sometimes express individual sentiments which are not shared by all the people. And through their dissemination they take on the final and purely demotic type, because the women who repeat them for a short while, correct the technical and linguistic imperfections, fill in the gaps and cast out or assimilate the alien elements.*

In this excerpt, Politis sets forth his central views on folk creation. He observes that works collected and published in the periodical *Laographia* have technical, formal imperfections. In the laments there is the creator, who is as a rule a woman. However, he ascertains that sometimes these creations are not aesthetically perfect, which is because the laments were created "to meet a temporary need". In other words, it is not only the pain but also the need to declare an identity, on the part of the creator, as well as to ratify and publicize his/her verses, which push him/her to choices that do not permit aesthetic processing of the text.

So, with regard to the "lament for the king" (Politis 1912–1913: 272), created by the illiterate peasant from Itylos, Karambelas, Politis notes that "the creator, perhaps a compelling improviser, was persuaded by the formality of the occasion and the magnitude of the subject to display his art, and for this reason probably he deemed it good to make a rhyming lament, but unaccustomed to using rhyme, he was forced to subject his meanings to its demands, and so are explained the hasty lines and the fillings in" (Ibid.).

However, we should point out a difference in the laments created for the king. They were sung in a church, in front of the entire congregation, in contrast to the laments sung in the home of the deceased. By taking into account Caraveli-Chaves's view that the "poetic devices within a living oral tradition cannot be approached only in terms of textual aspects, such as sets of opposition, but through a system of continuous dialogue between aesthetic considerations and social functions" (1980: 156), we are able to understand the priorities of those who sang the laments for the king. What had priority for them was the social function, in which is included both their personal position in the local society but also in the State or national environment (kingdom), which contributed to the downgrading of the aesthetic result.

The composer of the lament borrows from the tradition of rhyme, possibly because he believes that this befits the head of state, the dead king. Marigo Leontakianakou too resorts to this poetic form in "another lament for the king" (Politis 1912–1913: 273), in which "the lamenter tried to process more technically through the rhyme, but she did not follow this type systematically". In this spirit, that is in order to transcend the local normality, she does not follow the traditional eight-syllable line (Seremetakis 1990: 482) but introduces rhythm and rhyme, which is not an essential element in the poetry of Inner Mani (Morgan 1973: 273), as well as the fifteen-syllable line and other motifs, which draw from laments of other regions. Specifically, the rhyme, but mainly the fifteen-syllable line, contributes to the endeavour of redefining the meaning of the content of the laments, given that it is also related to epic poetry[12].

To return to the issue of improvisation, I stress my reservation as to the degree or even the actuality of improvisation. Politis admits in his comments from Kynouria that "we corrected the lines for which the restoration was obvious, enclosing the words removed or added, respectively in square [...] and in angle <....> brackets" (681). To summarize:

1. Politis confesses to making interventions himself, with the aim of adapting the formal elements to what he and the folklorists consider as suiting the specific genre of folk poetry (Seremetakis 1990: 489).

2. The recorders of the laments are schoolmasters, philologists with PhDs and headmasters of the region, who, although it is not written anywhere, will have been close to their teacher in the Faculty of Letters of the University of Athens, Professor Nikolaos Politis. Moreover, it is common knowledge that Politis had organized a wide-cast network of collaborators throughout Greece, who recorded and dispatched folklore material to him; this was particularly true for the Peloponnese and even more for Mani, which neighboured his birthplace, Kalamata.

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3. What is of interest is the manner of recording. As a rule, the recording of the lament songs is not primary. Researchers are not present at the time the laments are being delivered. Therefore, in order to record the lament, they consult the lamenters after the ceremony, or other sources. The lament for Mitsos Demestichas "was written down at the dictation of P. Demestichas himself" (Manolakos 1912–1913: 680), brother of the dead soldier, who was literate. "Another case is this of Despo, wife of Stelios Georgoulis who fell in Epirus on 7 January 1913." Despo capitalized on the opportunity of the lamenting of another deceased and created a lament for her own deceased, which "the lamenter herself wrote down at my request", as Politis notes (Kastri, Kynouria, 681).

A second source is the relatives and other members of the community[13]. "The first was said to some persons in Kotroni by the brother of the slain Petros Michail Michalakakos, from whom I heard it and I wrote it down", writes one of Politis's collaborators in the region of Mani (Manolakos 1912–1913: 675). We may also include in this category the recording by the groups of children who learnt by heart the lament for the dead king and sang it to collect money, in the same way as carol-singers do. The lament composed by Karambelas in Itylos was also recorded by this source. "It seems that the lament was very pleasing, because even children, having learnt it by heart, toured the villages and sang it for money. The way the lament was used by the children was according to information from Epameinonda N. Basoukeas, who told us about the song, which he wrote down in another village, where it was sung by children" (Politis 1912–1913: 272). The same happened also with the lament that Marigo A. Leontakianakou composed for the king, which "groups of children sang, coming to the house" (Dimopoulos 1912–1913: 273).

4. Publication and literacy. The laments for the king were published in the Kalamata newspaper *Neos Tachydromos*. "It was printed in Kalamata in a small newspaper", comments Politis, "to whom the headmaster of Arpharas, Dimopoulos, sent it, who pointed it out, accompanied by the issue of the newspaper *Tachydromos*, which had also published it" (Politis 1912–1913: 272). Doctor S. Tsaphos does the same with another lament which was sung in Areopolis in memory of King George I. "It was published in the issue of 31 March of the newspaper *Neos Tachydromos*, published in Kalamata", writes Politis (1912–1913: 692).

All these snippets of information cast doubts on what we know about the ceremonial performance, as well as about the climate of extempore composition of the lament. Reference has been made to the extensive presence of historical and diplomatic events in the laments, something that changes the typical traits of the specific genre. It is transmuted from a song about the pain for the loss of loved ones to a hymn lauding the sacrifice for the survival of

the national collectivity. Beyond this arises the issue of improvised creation, which touches on the aforesaid transformation. Even in the laments for Maniot soldiers the female lamenters, although in the majority illiterate, handle with competence the contemporary historical events of the Balkan Wars, which they incorporate into their poetic compositions.

This fact raises the question of their sources. It seems, however, that in Mani there is a diffuse literacy (the recorders have university education)[14], while it seems that the laments become known to the entire community. As far as the laments for the king are concerned, these are published in newspapers of the nearest urban centre (Kalamata), are printed in pamphlets which are possibly distributed, and also constitute narrative material for groups of children, who use them to collect pocket money. The inclusion of the laments for the king in the repertoire of the groups of children also attests to the response of the public, which rewards the children for their effort. This is material that creates channels of communication and reciprocity between the oral creation, the publication of the laments in newspapers and their transformation into historical genealogy which disseminates the historical information. This was always the case with itinerant bards, who roved from place to place, singing and publicizing important events. Therefore, in this particular case we cannot speak about improvised spontaneous creation. The illiterate women lamenters come into contact with this material through the aforesaid channels. And the doubting of the extempore creation is augmented in the case of the laments for the king, for which we do not know whether they were sung or read by their creators, who had written them prior to the memorial service in the churches.

5. The epic genealogy. The laments for the king are transformed into a newspaper column but they are also a means of diffusing historical knowledge and forming national consciousness on the margins of public space. Both the laments for the soldiers and, primarily, the corresponding ones for the dead king change the character of the genre. They become part of an epic historical process in which they meet with corresponding genres of the past, which spread the historical information and at the same time reinforce the cohesion of the group. The giving of new meaning to the familiar formal traits of the lament plays a major role in this process.

NOTES

1 "For the Maniots, the singing of *moiroloi* (lament) connotes 'crying one's fate' (*moira*)" (Seremetakis 1990: 482)

2 The antiphonic construction of pain is central to the truth-claiming strategies of Maniot women when in conflict with various aspects of the social structure. Pain is considered indispensable to the production and reception of truthful discourse in lament performances: a value that unites the biographical, historical and emotional dimensions of laments (Seremetakis 1990: 483).

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3 "The use of pain has been identified as a technique for the detachment of the self from everyday social contexts and identities" (Seremetakis 1990: 484–485).

4 The military and political leaders in America realized the importance of creating a list of those "martyred" in the War of Independence, to the extent of encouraging the writing and performing of related works for the soldiers, something that the British troops were using too (Shaffer 2006: 4).

5 "The army was a natural profession for the men of Mani" (Morgan 1973: 292).

6 A town in North Greece, in the region of Macedonia.

7 "I describe lament performances as being organized around antiphonic dynamics and aesthetics that entail the interpenetration of the collective and the individual" (Seremetakis 1990: 482).

8 "The *bogasi* is a marker, worn by married women and maidens (*kalomoires* – good fates) on their dress. This *bogasi* is a red ribbon (as sign of joy), about six centimetres wide. It is sewn onto the dress at about the waist (and ...) it is the custom to remove it from the dress of widowed women" (Seremetakis 1990: 679).

9 "The songs of both mourners are extraordinary in the absence of the expected lamentation. The content is almost entirely political-international diplomacy seen through the eyes of peasant women in a remote province, naive and shrewd by turns. Dimosthinena explicitly rejects the idea of lamenting a person who had died for his country" (Morgan 1973: 293).

10 The gerontiki (γεροντική) was a kind of local board. So the folk poet uses a familiar word in order to refer to the London Summit and the following London Treaty (1913) which dealt with the borders in the Balkan peninsula after the Ottoman Empire had lost in the Balkan war.

11 A village in Eastern Macedonia (Greece)

12 "The fifteen-syllable epic-heroic ballads and laments, which have nationalistic evocations, are associated with the performances of men, while the eight-syllable laments are almost exclusively identified with the discourses of women" (Seremetakis 1990: 482).

13 "This lament was written down in Nyphion and sent to me by the assistant schoolteacher there" (Manolakos 1912–1913).

14 "Some of the women who were swearing about Venizelos were literate" (note of Manolakos, Christoliakos, cf. Politis 1912–1913: 671).

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